ing a long-term perspective on how Bengal's electorate has changed.

The exercise is proving technically complex. The 2002 list predates the delimitation process that redrew Bengal's assembly and booth boundaries. That would have scrambled voter lists, those listed under one booth or constituency being naturally reallocated to another. The party's data team is trying to overcome this challenge by using AI-based mapping to match names, addresses and demographic patterns.

"The old and new lists don't speak the same language," says a data coordinator working on the project. "In 2002, booth and constituency numbers were different. After delimitation, entire jurisdictions changed. So, we are training the AI model to detect logical voter shifts instead of treating every movement as a deletion." Data accuracy is a good in itself; in this case, it will also lend credence to any complaints.

Credibility is a vital need. Mamata's open accusation that the EC is working "hand in glove" with the BJP needs firepower to back it up. If the party's combat-readiness stands in sharp contrast to the confusion seen in other states, the weaponry needs to be sharp. As a party senior put it, "We cannot afford to lose the democratic ground under our feet because of faulty data." ■

Takeaways

- **The 'Save Bengal's Voters' campaign by TMC uses AI to claim deletions, additions**
- **90,000-odd workers pan out across Bengal in a huge voter verification drive**
- **In the next AI-led phase, the 2025 voter list will be tested against 2002 data**

▶ GUJARAT

NO HANDCUFFS FOR LIGHT SINS

The 'ease of doing business' ethos gets a major fillip as Gujarat decriminalises 516 offences in a new Bill

By **Jumana Shah**

AS AN ENTIRE ONE-THIRD OF ITS imprisonment clauses go off the statute, ease of doing business just got easier in Gujarat. Actually, for a lot of the state's business class, life wasn't as easy as legend might have had it. A 2022 study had found that Gujarat's 1,469 imprisonment clauses were the highest in the country. Now, that has been hacked down to 953. The Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, passed by the state assembly in September, has decriminalised 516 offences.

To be more precise, the punitive burden they carry has been lightened to more rational levels. Decriminalisation doesn't mean blanket amnesty. Instead, criminal sanctions or conviction-based fines have been dropped for administrative penalties—with these getting tightened to ensure deterrence.

A LIGHTER SENTENCE

Of the 516 tweaks, jail has been outright axed in one, and 17 of the modified provisions trade the threat of 'imprisonment or fine' for civil monetary penalties enforced by the relevant administration's officers. In the remaining 498, fines upon conviction—which naturally entail the full judicial process—have been replaced with civic penalties, again with stiffer monetary hits so that there's no laissez faire for offenders.

To enable this shift, nearly 11 state laws have been amended across six departments: urban development, labour and employment, Narmada and water resources, industries and mines, agriculture and cooperation, and finance.

ANI



EASY DOES IT CM Bhupendra Patel with agri exporters at a 'Vibrant Gujarat' event in Mehsana, Oct. 9

Long in coming, the Bill is a response to a key industry demand. It sought reforms by painting the picture of a regulatory quicksand that inevitably swallows up the smaller players. "This brings in a new era of doing business in Gujarat," says Premraj Keshyep, chairman, CII's Gujarat State Council. "It is a declaration of trust in the business community and will benefit MSMEs the most. We are no longer burdened with outdated regulations."

For instance, under the APMC Act, imprisonment up to one month for market entry violations has been replaced with a Rs 25,000 penalty. Keshyep recalls particu-